

(chocolate-coated or otherwise), bargain store cheese and cracker combos by the case, dried fruit, raisin, and sunflower kernel mixture, and dried cereals are other ideas.

3. Finger foods

This strategy really goes a long way toward breaking up the monotony of the traditional bag lunch. Finger food is also great for those who don't have a long break for lunch and need to be nibbling on it in stages throughout the day. Consider hard-boiled eggs, cold chicken drumsticks, homemade version "lunchables," pinwheel appetizer-style sandwiches (tortillas rolled up with your favorite filling spread and sliced into rounds works great for this), and self-cut string cheese snacks from bulk block mozzarella. Ham and cheese cubes you can snag with a toothpick are also great for cutting carbs as well as for schoolchildren who like to try something different.

4. Celebrate your sandwich

Let's face it. Tuna salad, while affordable, just really doesn't cut it long term. Neither does PB&J. I'm not saying there's anything wrong with those sandwich selections. But most people (including myself) will

not stick with the "take my lunch to work" resolution if they get bored too quickly. If you grow your own basil, caprese sandwiches can be quite affordable. Another one is za'atar with olive oil as a spread, combined with mozzarella and roma tomatoes. A little curry powder in with your chicken salad can really help a lot, as can a pinch or two of horseradish. Alternative greens to lettuce (spinach, basil, radicchio, etc.) and homegrown sprouts can also help. A break from the traditional mayo for a spread can keep you motivated as well (think hummus or mashed avocado). Try a wrap, a roll, or a different grain entirely if you are bored with your regular white bread.

5. Dunkin' and dippin' combos

I'm partial to this, because I'm a dunker from way back. In addition to the age-old carrots and peanut butter, here are a few ideas you may not have thought of. Tortilla chips with salsa, guacamole, or ranch sauce. Celery with a multi-ingredient cream cheese spread (think smoked salmon or pineapple). Mini cocktail meatballs with sweet and sour dip. Pita-bread chips with hummus. There are many fun combos to keep your interest in brown bagging.